The amphibious assault was intended near the town of Trinidad. One advantage was that should the landing fail, the Escambray mountains were only three miles away. Brigade 2506 (so described after the identity number of its first casualty in training) could regroup to wage a campaign of guerrilla war. On 11 March, however, President Kennedy decided that the Trinidad plan was 'too spectacular' and risked exposing US involvement. 'It sounds like D-Day,' he told Bissell and instructed him to, 'reduce the noise level of this thing.'[41] So, a new landing site was sought. Bissell hurriedly identified sites on the Zapata peninsula, near the Bay of Pigs *(Bahia de Cochinos),* 200 miles west of Trinidad.

The CIA inexplicably failed to grasp that some eighty miles of mangrove swamp and dense jungle lay between the Bay of Pigs and the Escambray mountains. When Kennedy approved the new plan (Operation Zapata), he mistakenly thought the fallback option of a guerrilla campaign remained viable. The basic idea remained the same. If the landing was successful it would act as catalyst for an uprising against Castro. If things went wrong, the brigade could fight in the mountains. The President believed he was authorising a limited and deniable operation. And to compound the difficulties facing Brigade 2506, he then also insisted on a night-time attack.

The decision whether to proceed was becoming urgent. Castro continued to consolidate support (and remove opposition) among the Cuban people; the rainy season was approaching; President Fuentes of Guatemala was pressing for removal of the training camps (details of which were appearing in Guatemalan and US newspapers, including *The New York Times*); over twenty Soviet MiG-17s had arrived (though their Cuban pilots were still being trained in Czechoslovakia). Kennedy was presented with the choice of 'now or never'.

A handful of people counselled Kennedy against proceeding. William Fulbright, the Chairman of the Senate Foreign Relations Committee, privately wrote to the White House that '[the] Castro regime is a thorn in the flesh, not a dagger in the heart.'[42] Fulbright warned Kennedy directly that 'To give this activity even covert support is of a piece with the hypocrisy and cynicism for which the United States is constantly